European clubs, might be interested in signing me if things didn't workout at Old Trafford. But all that was daydreaming. I never wanted to do anything else but sign on the dotted line for the only club I'd ever played for. I knew that. Tony knew that. And so did United.

As the 2001/02 season wore on, we got closer and closer to the right deal. I wanted to be able to sign out on the field before a game at Old Trafford. After all the speculation, I wanted the people that mattered—United's supporters—to see it happen for themselves, especially as I hadn't been able to play since the Deportivo game. The next to last home game was against Arsenal. That was the night I'd set my heart on and I did what I could to hurry Tony along. As it turned out, there were a couple of tiny last-minute hitches. Just as well. Arsenal came up and won 1–0 which meant they won the title; and did the Double, in fact. It was a real low point for the club, to lose it in our own backyard. Although I think the disappointment spurred us on the following year, that night wouldn't have been the ideal time to celebrate me signing a new deal. That waited until the following Saturday instead, when we were at home to Charlton. It was perfect. The sun was shining. The manager came out on the field with me and gave me a hug in front of 65,000 fans. No doubt at all, Old Trafford was where I felt I belonged. I'd known all along the new contract was going to happen, whatever anyone else had been saying, but putting pen to paper was still a really satisfying moment.

My future felt settled. The second metatarsal, the medical experts told me, had healed. Suddenly everything was clear. I just had to concentrate on getting myself ready for England and for a World Cup that was now only a couple of weeks away. We had the send-off, at home in Sawbridgeworth, the next evening. Come Monday, we'd be leaving for Dubai to start our preparations for Japan. The idea was to combine a party for the England squad with an event which could raise money for my principal charity. We even managed to sell television rights for the night to ITV. Some of the arrangements had to be left to the last minute. I didn't know who Sven was going to take to the World Cup, so we couldn't be sure which players to invite until the squad was announced. In the meantime, we had a great time putting together the guest list. Lots of friends from soccer, of course, soccer greats from the past, and stars from other sports along with some famous musicians and actors as well.

To help raise more money for charity, we set just a few tables aside for paying guests too. We got in touch with my sponsors, people Victoria works with, and other companies we thought might be keen. They were all taken in no time. People knew it was going to be a special evening, I think, and they